professed expert status and position of authority within the British government to make him an obstruction for the Indian government. The fact that Delhi had no reliable advocate in London to support its position meant that it was doomed to being disregarded in this period. Only once Curzon's forward policies had proved futile did the Indian government's more pragmatic ideas find support. Even then, however, Delhi was still not afforded the credit for its foresight when it came to Britain's relations with South Asia. Ultimately, it is hard not to feel that had London simply followed the advice of Delhi in the first place, it could have avoided many headaches during this period. As it is, it was lucky for Britain that the Bolshevik government also had fundamental problems with its Asian policy in the years after 1918. Indeed, it is interesting to note that both Britain and Russia were essentially trying to achieve the same ends in Central and South Asia – that of extending their own influence in the region at the expense of the other – albeit through different means. But both Moscow and London appeared to fall foul of pan-Islamic and nationalist feeling. Propaganda efforts such as the Baku Congress and the KUTV might alarm some British officials, but ultimately they were simply a lot of hot air.

For despite all of these Bolshevik efforts 'revolution in Asia – in the short term – proved even more illusory than revolution in Europe'.[12] While nationalist leaders might find it convenient to have a potential ally against imperial Britain, it did not mean that they were willing to replace one domineering foreign power with another.[13] The quality of the Asian recruits was also a real problem for Moscow in these early years after the October revolution. Most of those students of the KUTV, for example, were either incompetent or simply taking advantage of the Bolshevik willingness to feed and clothe them. Some revolutionaries, such as Barakatullah, were simply looking for any support in their struggle against the British. A high number were impractical intellectuals.[14] The one thing which the Bolshevik government did have going for it was its pragmatism, and its ability to learn and adapt to the current situation. For example, when it came to its failed first attempt at invading Bokhara in March 1918 'Lenin drew the theoretical lesson of this event when he wrote that it was necessary to move cautiously in the matter of revolution' in the Muslim world.[15] Unlike the British foreign secretary, the Russian leader was willing to be flexible in how he approached the Asian question.